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INTERVIEW

# FITNESS SHOULD BE ENJOYABLE

Actress Samantha backs **pickleball's growth** in India, highlighting its accessibility, inclusivity, and future through the World Pickleball League.

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India's growing passion for pickleball has seen it evolve from a leisure activity to a competitive sport. The latest milestone in its journey is the World Pickleball League, hosted at Mumbai's CCI-Brabourne Stadium. The league featured 48 players across six franchises, including international stars from Japan, Spain, South Korea, Australia, the USA, and the UK.

Among the franchise owners was actress Samantha Ruth Prabhu, who helms the Chennai Super Champs. In a conversation with *Sportstar*, she spoke about her decision to invest in the sport, its accessibility, and its future in India.

## What drew you to pickleball as your first venture into sports entrepreneurship?

When I first met Gaurav Natekar, (WPBL promoter), I never planned to own a sports team. But fitness and well-being have always been priorities for me. Anything I associate with should have a broader impact.

Growing up, academics took precedence over sports. Now, when friends invite me to play, it doesn't come naturally. That's why I love pickleball — it's easy to pick up at any stage in life. You don't need years of training, just a court and a paddle. I want everyone, girls and older people, to take it up for a healthier life.

## You've called pickleball a 'non-intimidating' sport. What makes it so accessible?

Unlike tennis, which requires rigorous training, pickleball is more like a social activity. There's no excessive physical strain, and even after playing for two hours, you don't feel drained. It's a great way to unwind with friends while staying active.

## Chennai has seen a surge in pickleball courts. What does the future look like for the sport here?

Chennai has always embraced new sports. Who would have thought the city would take to surfing? But it did. From the Ironman Challenge to endurance races, Chennaiites are up for a challenge. They will welcome pickleball the same way.

## Pickleball has near-equal participation between men and women. How significant is that?

Around 45% of players are women — that's remarkable. Most sports see men's competitions thrive first, but pickleball is different. It's also age-inclusive, with older players actively competing. The sense of community in this sport is special.

## Your team's lone Indian player, Sonu, has a great story. How do you

## see this league helping him?

He's an inspiring kid who has worked incredibly hard to reach this stage. I'm proud of him. This league is just the beginning — we want to build a grassroots system for players like him. My involvement doesn't end with the tournament. We're committed to developing the sport further.

## For those unfamiliar with pickleball, why should they try it?

Because sport is important. Fitness should be enjoyable, and pickleball is a perfect alternative if you dislike solo workouts. It's social, engaging, and, trust me, extremely addictive!



NIGAMANTH P